



Clay Bears & Quail

Grade 4

Clay



Los Altos School District • 201 Covington Road • Los Altos • CA • 94024 • 650.947.1195
www.losaltosartdocents.org

Last Revised: December 2025

CLAY BEARS & QUAIL

Length: 75 minutes

Number of docents: 2

Purpose:

- To further explore the medium of clay while creating one of the California state symbols, the grizzly bear or valley quail
- To develop skills in 3-D modeling to capture characteristics of bear/quail
- To help develop concepts of form and texture

Academic Support: Social Studies curriculum study of California

Visual Arts Standards:

- Brainstorm individual and collaborative approaches to a creative art or design problem. (4.VA:Cr1.1)
- Explore and invent art-making techniques and approaches. (4.VA:Cr2.1)
- When making works of art, utilize and care for materials, tools, and equipment in a manner that prevents danger to oneself and others. (4.VA:Cr2.2)

Unit Contains: Supply box

Materials docent will bring:

- Laminated pictures of quail and grizzly bears
- Sample of clay bears and quail
- Clay texture tools, i.e. plastic forks, popsicle sticks

Materials teacher will provide:

- Red Clay
- Small container for water per student
- Clay board per student
- Optional butcher paper to cover desks and extra clay texture tools

Room set-up:

Display laminated pictures of bears and quail in the room. Do not distribute clay until AFTER the demonstration. Either make up a demo sample up to Part 1 or do a second one while the kids are working so you have another piece of clay to use to demo both a bear and a quail.

****If the clay has already been distributed, say to the students: I'm going to ask you to do something very difficult...the hardest thing in the whole lesson...NOT TO TOUCH THE CLAY until we are ready to make our sculptures!**

OR

Do demo on carpet and then excuse kids to their desks.

INTRODUCTION

Can you guess what we are going to make today? grizzly bears/valley quail

Why have we chosen these for fourth graders? CA study

These are two of our state symbols. Can you name some others? golden poppy, redwood, golden trout, etc.

Has anyone ever seen a grizzly bear or a valley quail?

Look at the pictures. What makes the grizzly different from other bears? hump between shoulders, long, coarse hair that's brownish tipped in white—gives them their name

What is the distinguishing feature of the quail? Top-knot or plume on head, markings around head and breast

Show samples (except for glazed quail) and point out various features:

BEAR - Different positions: standing, sitting up

- Hump: between shoulder blades
- Hind legs: larger, more muscular
- Neck: not much of it
- Tail: small, hardly noticeable
- Ears: rounded, small, close to head
- Nose: not too flat but not as pointed as a fox
- Head: notice turn of which brings it alive! Can make by giving it a gentle turn after it is finished
- Posture: friendly / ferocious?

QUAIL - What is different from the picture?

- Base: legs done in clay would be too fragile, could be log or rock, legs can be etched into the base
- Top-knot: much thicker (will break off during firing if too thin)
- Head: can tilt forward or down as if pecking at food on ground
- Feathers: long, flat feathers in wings and tail; short, fan-shaped feathers on breast

Show glazed quail sample

You are going to sculpt either a bear or quail today. I'll demonstrate a few steps for each and then have you do those. Then I'll ask you to put down your sculpture to get the next steps for each and then you can do it. We'll go back and forth 3 times. I appreciate that you watch the instructions for both even if you aren't ready for the

next steps yet. This way, you'll be ready to go at your own pace and the techniques used for each animal are very similar.

INSTRUCTION – *Docent demonstrates each part, students watch, then do. It may be helpful to bring the kids to the carpet for your demonstration each time.*

PART 1: Making a Potato

First, we'll all turn our block of clay into a potato shape. Do this by holding the clay in one hand and tap with the heel of your other hand on the corners and edges. Rotate the clay in your hand so you are working on all sides. *Have students do motion in air as you demonstrate with your clay.*



This may take some time so be patient.

Once you are happy with your potato shape, we'll start to shape the clay to form two segments. While still holding the clay in your hand, about 2 fingers from the top use your thumb and pointer finger to gently squeeze, then turn and squeeze again until you have a shape that has two segments. *Have students do motion in air as you demonstrate with your clay.*

While you are molding the clay, decide whether you'd like to do a bear or a quail.

PART 2: Forming the Body – *Bring students to carpet or front of the room for your demo.*

Next, we'll form the bodies for our sculpture. This is where you have to make the decision about whether you are going to make a bear or a quail. I'll show you the steps to make both bodies and then let you start. Watch carefully as many of the techniques are used for both sculptures.

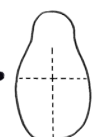
Quail:

1. Turn the shape so that the smaller segment is on the bottom. Gently tap the clay on your board to create a base. You can turn this base into a nest, rocks or etch in legs later.
2. Use a team of fingers and the heel of your hand, pull and shape a head and tail. Notice the direction of the head and tail, they can be pointed up or down. Make sure your tail is thick and not too long. Keep center portion of body large enough to maintain BALANCE of bird. Most of weight should be in the center.



Bear:

1. Use a team of fingers and the palm of your hand to shape the head. The neck should be very thick as a grizzly bear.
2. Hold the clay body in your hand make a + sign in the body of the clay with a tongue depressor. Start with the line down the center of the body, push the tongue depressor into the clay and pull out. Next, make a



vertical line a bit ABOVE the center since hind legs are more muscular. Now use your fingers and the heel of your hand to get in there and form the legs by pushing and molding the clay. Make the legs short and stubby with the hind legs heavier than the front legs. Next decide if your bear will be standing or sitting and tap it on the board gently.



PART 3: Body Parts - *Bring students to carpet or front of the room for your demo.*

Once you have finished the main shape of your sculpture, it's time to add some more body parts. For most of these, we'll be using our fingers and hands to pull and mold the clay. We'll start with the head for both. To give your sculpture some character, turn the head slightly for animation.

Quail: Top knot, beak, wings

1. Use your finger and thumb to gently pull and shape some of the clay in the head to form a little beak. Gently pull out a top knot on the head and curl over slightly.
2. Gently push up clay from underneath to form a slight bulge for the wings. This can be done with your hand or using a tongue depressor.



Bear: Ears, snout, tail, hump

1. Push and pull small, rounded ears close to the head. Form a blunted snout by gently molding with your fingers. Then either open it to create a mouth with a popsicle stick or just mark a line with the clay wire.
2. Using your fingers or the tongue depressor, push out a tiny bump of a tail. To make the grizzlies hump, place finger and thumb on both sides by the shoulder and push up slightly.



PART 4: Adding Details - *Bring students to carpet or front of the room for your demo.*

After you have completed the body parts, it's time to add the details and texture that will make your sculpture come to life. You'll be using the clay tools to create a variety of imprints and textures. Keep in mind that clay shrinks as it dries so make the texture deeper than normal.

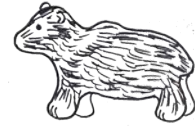
Quail: Eyes, feathers, legs, nest

1. Press in with clay wire and/or end of straw to make eyes on the sides of the head.
2. With clay wire draw in head and bib area markings and to make the legs and/or nest.
3. Use the clay wire and popsicle stick to make short and long feathers on the breast and wings.



Bear: Eyes, nostril, fur, claws

1. Press in with clay wire to make eyes on the front of the head and for nostrils.
2. Use a fork and/or clay wire to create a furry texture and claws.



Finishing

When you are finished, with your finger, push a hole from the underside of the bear or quail to allow air to penetrate thickest part. Really go deep and hollow out the piece so that no part of the clay sculpture is more than ½" thick.

With clay wire, incise in your **first name** and room number so that it can be read.

Place sculpture in designated area.

Clean up desk by returning tools to caddy and boards to cart.

DOCENT TIPS:

At end of lesson, re-check holes in each and every piece.

Place clay pieces somewhere out of the way to dry. Make sure they are not directly under heating or air conditioning vents. Clay is dry and ready for firing when it is no longer cool to the touch. The teacher should contact the "kiln master" at their school to arrange for firing (this information was emailed to them in their lesson reminder).

Other suggestions

Water: use only at the end of modeling and ONLY if clay is dry. Dip a finger in water and shake off excess before smoothing out any cracks.

To comment on a student's work, always ask child if you may pick up their work ("May I pick this up?") or point out features ("Look at these great ears, top-knot, etc.")

Show student on your own piece of clay a particular move, such as making the hump or top-knot.

BACKGROUND

California The Golden State

Capitol: Sacramento

Acres in State: 100,353,920

Length of Coastline: 1,341 miles

Highest Point: 14,496 feet (Mount Whitney)

Lowest Point: 282 feet below sea level (Death Valley)

State Flag: Bear Flag

State Colors: Blue and gold

State Tree: Redwood

State Flower: Golden poppy

State Fish: Golden trout

State Bird: Valley quail

State Insect: Dog-faced butterfly

State Animal: Grizzly bear

State Rock: Serpentine

State Mineral: Gold

State Motto: Eureka (I have found it!)

Grizzly Bear

- A large fierce bear, *Ursus horribilis*, which is larger and heavier than the Black Bear. Some weigh as much as 1000 pounds. Most grizzlies look larger than they really are because of their long, coarse hair and loose skin.
- Grizzlies once inhabited from the Great Plains to the Pacific Coast, but are now confined to National Parks and a few areas of wilderness, mostly parts of Alaska and Canada.
- Their hair is brownish, often tipped with white, giving them the “grizzled” appearance that account for their name.
- The hump between the shoulders distinguishes a Grizzly from a Brown or Black bear.
- The legs are short and powerful with long but blunt claws.
- He sees poorly with his small eyes but has a very keen sense of smell.

California Valley Quail (and birds in general)

- A bird’s skeleton is rigid except for its neck. The neck must be flexible so the beak can reach every part of the body to clean and smooth the feathers. A sparrow has more bones in its neck than a giraffe!
- The bones are light and hollow.
- Muscles make up more than half a bird’s body weight. Most of the muscles are in the breast, needed for moving the wings.
- Feathers are formed like the leaf of a fern: the center is a strong, stiff shaft. Feathers are different on different parts of the body. The wings and tail have long, stiff feathers for flight. The breast has smaller and softer feathers for warmth.

CLAY

Clay is stored at the school site. Ask the school clerk/secretary for its location, if needed. Teachers should arrange to have clay in classroom before lesson starts.

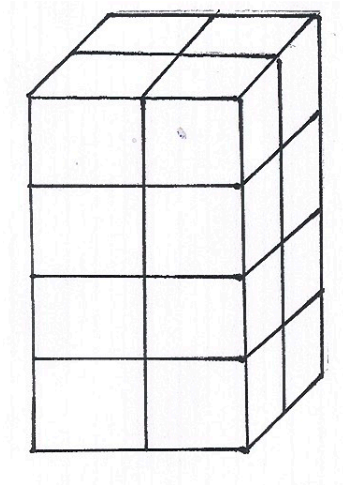
CUT CLAY

Docent will cut the clay when he/she arrives. Please follow the diagrams below to understand how clay is to be cut. The direction of cuts and the number of pieces depends on each specific lesson. In the period between cutting the clay and distributing it to the students, it is best if the pieces are kept covered with a piece of plastic sheet to prevent drying. This is even more important in winter when classroom heating is in full force.

AMOUNT OF CLAY REQUIRED

One 25-pound block of clay or 1 bag makes 16 cubes approximately 2 ¾" square. Only cut the amount of clay needed and leave the rest uncut. Any unused clay should be returned to sealed bag

First use an open paperclip or pencil to mark all sides of the block of clay into cubes. Pull the cutting line or string through the block of clay along the marks, horizontally first, then vertically. Hint: You may have to look back and forth on both sides of the block as you cut. **GO SLOWLY.** Cut only the number of cubes you need for the class, one for the docent's demonstration, one for the assistant, and one for each parent volunteer.



HINTS FOR SUCCESS

In all pull/push units, carefully poke a hole with finger up through the piece from the bottom. Use the end of an open paperclip to punch holes in finished work taking care to make holes in hidden features such as eyes, nose, mouth, and texture. This will help the drying process and relieve trapped air. If there are heavy pieces such as a head or tail, prop these pieces up with a wadded up piece of paper (not paper towel) so it doesn't fall, break off, or crack during drying process.



DRYING

Place clay out of the way to dry, and away from heating and air conditioning vents. Clay is dry when it no longer feels cool to the touch. Depending on the weather, clay will take longer or less time to dry. Unfired clay is called greenware, and is very delicate/breakable so take care when moving.

FIRING

There is a designated person for firing clay at most schools. Teacher should contact the appropriate "kiln master" to make arrangements for firing the pieces.

Parent Instructions for Clay Bears & Quail

Thank you for volunteering today!

Please help by:

Setting up lesson supplies

- Distribute clay board, wire, popsicle stick, tongue depressor, straw, and fork for each student.
- The docent will tell you when to distribute the clay.
- Fill water containers with ¼" water. Docent will tell you when to give to students.



During the lesson

- Listen carefully to the docent instructions so you understand the techniques and steps of the project.
- While students are working, move around the room to help all students with the techniques shown.
- Please do not touch the student's clay pieces. Demonstrate on your own clay piece if a student needs more direction.
- Stop working with the students and listen when the docent is giving instructions, then continue when instructions are finished.

Additional tips

- Please don't work on students' art — demonstrate on scrap materials
- Ask Art Docents if a student needs extra help
- Make sure students write first name and room number on bottom of piece
- Have fun!

Helping clean-up

- Ask the teacher about leftover clay scraps and where the finished pieces should go.
- Collect clay boards and return to the school's clay cart. No need to wipe these down.
- Collect clay tools (wire, popsicle stick, tongue depressor, straw, and fork) and return to the Art Docent Unit. No need to wipe these down.
- **Any unused clay should be returned to sealed bag and left at site.**

LOS ALTOS
art
DOCENTS



Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
1985	Kris Haas	Developed
March 2012	Kimberly Dickerson	Reformatted for continuity
May 2012	Kimberly Dickerson	More instructions for glazing provided for teacher
February 2013	Curriculum Committee	Added suggestions for docents to give feedback to children
December 2013	Kimberly Dickerson	Clay Handling Instructions for Teachers added
October 2015	Kimberly Dickerson	Removed covering of clay with plastic
March 2018	Kimberly Dickerson	Instructions for checking hole in pieces added
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
February 2023	Kimberly Dickerson	Changed format of giving instructions so that students could get hands on clay earlier and to maintain engagement.
June 2024	Curriculum Committee	Parent Volunteer Instructions added
January 2025	Ann Kanodia	Typos fixed, name on bottom if space, no wet paper towels in holes removed.
August 2025	Kimberly Dickerson	Added information about getting and returning clay.
December 2025	Joan Takenaka	Write first name on bottom of piece.